Although she has a considerable body of work in *khayal*, *thumri*, *dadra* over the decades, most lay listeners in India still respond to 'Ab Ke Sawan', which released in 1999 and is aired on radio even today every time it rains somewhere in India! We ask Mudgal how she straddles the divide between pop and more traditional/folk/classical musical forms. "My involvement with *khayal* and *thumri* has been a sustained one, while I have only occasionally done popular music. The fact that some of the tracks I recorded decades ago still remain in circulation gives me great satisfaction. Almost on a daily basis, I am tagged on reels where people are dancing to my tracks. But that doesn't stop me from getting back to my tanpuras every day. And I feel quite blessed that despite being a first-generation musician, I'm identified as a musician/singer by so many people."

When asked to share some vignettes from her life in Delhi, her *riyaaz* and other joys, she says, "Music is an essential part of my life every single day. I can't and don't want to do without it at all. I have an indefatigable appetite for music as a listener. I travel usually for work, but I also make frequent trips to my home in Uttarakhand, which is really relaxing. I am a fairly avid reader, an enthusiastic foodie with almost 32 sweet teeth, and I am a crochet and knitting junkie too. And, oh yes, one of my daily rituals is to make my fur babies Ringo and Nargis sing with me, for a heavy fee that they demand... namely, biscuits!"

While she hasn't yet thought about a follow-up to her sparkling collection of short stories *Looking for Miss Sargam: Stories of Music and Misadventure (2019)*, she does write occasionally on music. Mudgal is clear in her focus: "For me, the future is always music, music and more music." ■

Priya Pathiyan

UNITED WE SING

Singer and composer **Kalyani Nair**'s new EP is the culmination of over a decade of collaboration with fellow musicians and singers



Kalyani Nair might have begun in the mainstream singing popular compositions under music director Vidyasagar around 2005, but in some counterintuitive fashion, she's more famous for her independent efforts like Harmonize Projekt and Yodhakaa. On the cinema front, even as work with regular collaborators like Santhosh Narayanan, Sean Roldan and Pradeep Kumar followed, she was always tied to the indie scene as a singer and arranger, and now, with The Indian Choral Ensemble, a mixed vocal group (whose most recent contribution can be seen in Coke Studio Tamil) with singers from all over the country. It's a project she founded with Karthik Manickavasagam. She's out with her EP as a composer, and the first song, 'Nam Tham', released at the end of July.

The beginning of this recent effort goes back over a decade, the days of Harmonize Projekt. She wrote the first draft of 'Nam Tham' in 2009. "I had this fascination for voices. I always wanted to start a big vocal group," she says. When she learned raag Kalavati during the early days of her training in Hindustani, the idea for a *bandish* came about. And then it just lay there. "The song travelled with me all the way till 2019, when I developed it into an independent choral piece." That wasn't the end of the story. There were these people and their voices, and they needed something new to rehearse every week because they enjoyed the process so much. "I had to write something new to get the group excited. Karthik was a pillar of support for me as he had a couple of students being a tutor at A.R. Rahman's KM Music Conservatory." Slowly, the group grew, people funneling in from Kalyani's own efforts, and the song became a fuller piece. "The genesis of the Indian Choral Ensemble cannot be separated from 'Nam Tham'," she says.

The Indian Choral Ensemble is a mixed vocal group founded by Kalyani Nair and Karthik Manickavasagam

Her group has been performing these songs in live concerts around Chennai for some time now. In addition to 'Nam Tham', there is 'Omanaththingal', the popular Malayalam lullaby penned by Irayimman Thampi for Swathi Thirunal. "This, too, happened accidentally when a fellow musician I was working with demanded something that already exists in Malayalam. I always wanted to do something in the language, so I came up with a fresh tune and arrangement for this one." Then there's 'Iru Manam', which will be released in October, and closing the EP is a Hindi version of 'Nam Tham'.

Kalyani finds it comforting to work with long-time collaborators. "I always feel that for the kind of music I write, which is ensemble music, it's important for people to work together and deliver. We have all rehearsed and shaped it as one before recording." ■

Aditya Shrikrishna